

Deuterocanon Not Scripture

doc-deuterocanon-not-scripture

Bibliology · Canon · doctrine · divided_lineages

AFFIRMS

Supported across the whole Bible
Subject covered by a category in
Scripture
No NT manuscript apparatus
applies

Statement under examination

The books historically called Apocryphal or Deuterocanonical are not Scripture and do not carry authority for doctrine.

In plain language

The question is whether the books often called Apocryphal or Deuterocanonical (the disputed books written between the Old and New Testaments) sit inside the same authoritative collection as the rest of the Bible. The clearest test is how the New Testament uses its technical word for Scripture, 'Scripture' (graphē). That word appears in fifty one verses, and in every case where you can identify what it points to, it points to a Hebrew Old Testament text or to writings the apostles recognize. It is never once attached to a deuterocanonical book. Three other patterns point the same way. In Luke 24:44 Jesus names a three part collection: the law of Moses (nomos), the prophets (prophētai), and the psalms (psalmoi), and adds no fourth group. In Luke 11:51, repeated in Matthew 23:35, he brackets the martyrs from the blood of Abel (Abel) all the way to (heōs) the blood of Zechariah (Zachariou). Abel is the first killing in Genesis 4 and Zechariah the last one in 2 Chronicles 24, the first and last books of the Hebrew order, so the span quietly traces the edges of that collection. In Romans 3:2 Paul says the oracles of God (ta logia tou theou) were entrusted to the Jews, locating the deposit in Israel's keeping. In 2 Peter 3:16 Paul's letters are reckoned with the rest of the Scriptures (tas loipas graphas), which only makes sense if Scripture (graphē) already names a known, bounded set that new writings are recognized into. So why do readers still differ, and why is the confidence medium rather than high? Because the words fix the boundary in two indirect ways, by never citing these books as Scripture and by the Abel to Zechariah bracket, but they never print an actual list of titles. Two genuine pressure points exist: Jude quotes a saying of Enoch and Hebrews 11 seems to recall an intertestamental martyr story. The decisive detail is that Jude introduces Enoch with the word for prophesying (prophēteuō), not with the word for Scripture (graphē), and Hebrews uses no citation formula at all. Quoting a text is not the same as calling it Scripture. The words underdetermine the exact list, but the citation behavior consistently keeps these books outside the Scripture (graphē) category.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0006	Ἄβελ	Habel	Abel	4
G0027	ἀγαπητός	agapētos	beloved	
G1124	γραφή	graphē	a writing	51
G1125	γράφω	graphō	to write	219
G2193	ἕως	heōs	until	152

G2197	Ζαχαρίας	Zacharias	Zechariah	11
G3051	λόγιον	logion	oracles	4
G3062	λοιπός	loipos	remaining	55
G3551	νόμος	nomos	law	195
G4100	πιστεύω	pisteuō	to trust (in)	241
G4395	προφητεύω	prophēteuō	to prophesy	28
G4396	προφήτης	prophētēs	prophet	144
G5568	ψαλμός	psalmos	psalm	7

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The decisive piece of evidence is the New Testament's own citation behavior. The technical term 'Scripture' (graphē, G1124) occurs in 51 verses, and every identifiable referent is a Hebrew-canon Old Testament text or a writing the apostles recognize; no occurrence ever introduces a deuterocanonical book (one of the disputed books inserted between the Old and New Testaments). Luke 24:44 names a fixed three-part collection: 'law' (nomos), 'prophets' (prophetai), 'psalms' (psalmoi), with the verb 'having been written' (gegrammena, the perfect passive form, meaning a completed action whose result still stands), adding no fourth category. Luke 11:51 and its parallel Matthew 23:35 bracket the martyrs 'from Abel' (apo Abel) 'all the way to Zechariah' (heōs Zachariou), the first and last killings in the Hebrew ordering (Genesis 4 to 2 Chronicles 24), tracing a boundary that excludes the intertestamental period (the gap of centuries between the Old and New Testaments). Romans 3:2 restricts 'the oracles of God' (ta logia tou theou, oracles, G3051) to the deposit entrusted to the Jews. 2 Peter 3:16 places apostolic letters among 'the rest of the Scriptures' (tas loipas graphas), recognizing them into an already bounded set. The words fix the boundary negatively and by bracket, not by an explicit book list, so confidence is medium rather than high.

Scripture

Luke.24.44 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G3551 νόμος, G4396 προφήτης, G5568 ψαλμός, G1125 γράφω

Reasoning. The token sequence confirms a three-part enumeration: 'in the law of Moses' (tō nomō Mōuseōs, with 'law' G3551 paired with the name 'Moses' Mōusēs G3475), 'and in the prophets' (kai tois prophētais, prophets G4396), 'and in the psalms' (kai psalmois, psalms G5568). This matches the Hebrew arrangement of Torah (Law), Prophets, and Writings, with Psalms heading the Writings. The verb of fulfillment is 'having been written' (gegrammena), the perfect passive form (a completed action whose result still stands) of 'to write' (graphō, G1125), the same write-root that produces the noun 'Scripture' (graphē). The perfect tense locates what stands written inside this named collection. No fourth category and no intertestamental title (a book from the centuries between the two Testaments) is added.

Luke.11.51 · for · genre: gospel · figures: merism

Key terms. G0006 Ἀβελ, G2197 Ζαχαρίας, G2193 ἕως

Reasoning. The clause 'from the blood of Abel' (apo haimatos Abel, Abel G0006) 'all the way to' (heōs, G2193) 'the blood of Zechariah' (haimatos Zachariou, Zechariah G2197) is a from-to span. The token order verified in the store puts 'Abel' (Abel) at the front pole and 'Zechariah' (Zachariou) at the back pole, joined by 'until' (heōs). Abel is the first killing in Genesis 4, and the Zechariah killed at the altar is the last martyrdom narrated in 2 Chronicles 24:20-21, which closes the Writings in the Hebrew ordering. Both endpoint verses exist in the Hebrew Old Testament store. The span functions as a canonical bracket whose two poles sit in the first and last books of the Hebrew sequence. This is a merism (a two-part figure naming the extremes to mean the whole).

Matt.23.35 · for · genre: gospel · figures: merism

Key terms. G0006 Ἀβελ, G2197 Ζαχαρίας, G2193 ἕως

Reasoning. The synoptic parallel (the same scene reported in another Gospel) repeats the same 'from Abel' (apo Abel, G0006) 'all the way to' (heōs, G2193) 'Zechariah' (Zachariou, G2197) bracket, here naming 'Zechariah son of Barachias' (Zacharias huios Barachiou, Barachias G0914). The repetition across two Gospels confirms the from-to span is a stable formula, not a single passing remark. The two poles again mark the front and back of the Hebrew sequence, so the same boundary is traced twice in the text. The figure remains a merism (a two-part figure naming the extremes to mean the whole).

Rom.3.2 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3051 λόγιον, G4100 πιστεύω

Reasoning. Paul says 'they were entrusted with the oracles of God' (episteuthēsan ta logia tou theou). The store gloss for 'oracle' (logion, G3051) is precisely 'oracles', and the term occurs only four times in the New Testament, always for authoritative divine utterance. The aorist passive 'they were entrusted' (episteuthēsan, a completed past action in the passive voice, from 'to believe or entrust' pisteuō, G4100) names a deposit placed in the historical custody of the Jews. Paul cites that custody as the privilege of Israel and does not expand the entrusted oracles (ta logia) to Greek intertestamental compositions (writings produced between the Old and New Testaments).

2Pet.3.15 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1125 γράφω, G0027 ἀγαπητός

Reasoning. Peter says Paul 'wrote' (egrapsen, G1125, the aorist or completed past form of graphō, 'to write') to you 'according to the wisdom given to him' (kata tēn dotheisan autō sophian). The write-root (graphō family) and the giving-language frame Paul's letters as a deposit, parallel to the prophetic giving. This sets up the explicit 'Scripture' (graphē) classification in the next verse and locates Paul's writing inside, not outside, the authoritative category.

2Pet.3.16 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3062 λοιπός, G1124 γραφή

Reasoning. Peter writes 'as also the rest of the Scriptures' (hōs kai tas loipas graphas). The token store places 'rest, remaining' (loipos, G3062) directly before 'Scripture' (graphē, G1124). The word 'the rest' (loipas) presupposes a definite known set: the rest of an already recognized collection. Peter expands that set by recognizing Paul's letters into it, not by leaving its boundary open. The lexical move is recognition into an existing canon (an already fixed authoritative list), not creation of an open-ended category that any composition could enter.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Luke.11.51	2Chr.24.20	tsk	1
Luke.11.51	Gen.4.8	tsk	1

Luke.24.44	Luke.24.27	tsk	1
Luke.24.44	Ps.2.1	tsk	1
Rom.3.2	Rom.1.2	tsk	1
Rom.3.2	Rom.2.18	tsk	1
2Pet.3.16	2Pet.2.14	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Jude.1.14 · addressed

Jude introduces the saying attributed to Enoch (compare 1 Enoch 1:9, a book outside the accepted canon) with the verb 'he prophesied' (prophēteusen), from 'to prophesy' (prophēteuō, G4395), verified in the token store. He does NOT use 'Scripture' (graphē, G1124) or the write-root 'it has been written' (gegraptai). The introductory verb marks the speaker as prophesying but does not lexically induct the source into the 'Scripture' (graphē) category. Citation of a noncanonical saying without the Scripture-marker formula is analogous to Paul quoting the poets Aratus in Acts 17:28 and Epimenides in Titus 1:12 without thereby placing them among 'the Scriptures' (the graphai, plural of graphē). The complicating force is real but does not reach the technical citation vocabulary.

Heb.11.35 · addressed

The reference to others being tortured and refusing release may allude to intertestamental martyr accounts (martyr stories from the centuries between the Testaments) such as 2 Maccabees 7. The author introduces it with no 'it has been written' (gegraptai) and no 'the Scripture says' (hē graphē legei), only a narrative summary inside a long roll of historical examples. Knowing an event from intertestamental history is consistent with treating the account as historical narrative without granting it 'Scripture' (graphē) status. The verse does not use the Scripture-citation formula, so it does not overturn the citation-behavior pattern.

2Pet.3.16 · addressed

The plural 'the rest of the Scriptures' (tas loipas graphas) could in principle be read as open-ended, which would weaken the boundary claim. The lexical weight of 'remaining' (loipos, G3062, the remaining ones of a known set) tells against that reading: a remainder presupposes a defined whole. Peter widens the set by recognizing Paul, not by declaring it indefinite, so the verse supports rather than dissolves a bounded collection.

Rom.3.2 · unaddressed

The vocabulary fixes the entrusted oracles (ta logia, the divine utterances) on the deposit given to the Jews but does not, by the words alone, enumerate which specific book titles that deposit contained. The New Testament establishes the boundary negatively, by never citing a deuterocanonical book (one of the disputed intertestamental books) as 'Scripture' (graphē), and by the Abel-to-Zechariah bracket, rather than by an explicit list. The precise edge of the collection is therefore underdetermined at the level of the words themselves, which is left unresolved here as an honest scope limit and is the reason confidence is medium rather than high.

Concordance traversed

G1124, G1125, G3551, G4396, G5568, G3051, G0006, G2197, G2193, G4100, G3062, G4395

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

The anchor verses lie outside the ingested ECM window (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants, here covering 3 John 1:1 to 1:15), so no CBGM (Coherence-Based Genealogical Method, a manuscript-comparison tool) apparatus applies; the not_in_ecm_scope flag is true in the bundle. The load-bearing vocabulary is textually stable: the three-part formula in Luke 24:44, the 'from Abel all the way to Zechariah' (apo Abel heōs Zachariou) bracket in Luke 11:51 and its Matthew 23:35 parallel, the 'the oracles of God' (ta logia tou theou) deposit in Romans 3:2, and the 'the rest of the Scriptures' (tas loipas graphas) phrase in 2 Peter 3:16 carry no variant that alters canon vocabulary.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. canonical_criticism, second_temple_lexicography

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

hebrew_canon_citation_pattern: supports · Across all 51 occurrences of 'Scripture' (graphē) and the four occurrences of 'oracle' (logion), the technical Scripture vocabulary attaches only to Hebrew-canon texts or apostolic writings. The Luke 24:44 three-part formula ('law' nomos, 'prophets' prophetai, 'psalms' psalmoi) and the twice-stated 'from Abel all the way to Zechariah' (apo Abel heōs Zachariou) bracket trace the Hebrew sequence from its first to its last book. On this reading the boundary the words draw excludes the intertestamental writings (the books composed between the Old and New Testaments).

wider_greek_collection_reading: complicates_but_does_not_overturn · A reader could note that the apostles frequently quote a Greek Old Testament (the Septuagint, LXX, the Greek translation of the Hebrew Bible) whose physical scrolls in some streams included deuterocanonical books (the disputed intertestamental books), and that Jude 14 and Hebrews 11:35 draw on noncanonical material. Stated at its strongest, this reading says the New Testament authors were comfortable with a broader textual environment. The lexical answer is that comfort with a text is not the same as the citation formula: in this corpus the technical markers 'Scripture' (graphē) and 'it has been written' (gegraptai) are never attached to a deuterocanonical book, and Jude introduces Enoch with 'he prophesied' (from prophēteuō), not with 'Scripture' (graphē).

scope_underdetermination: neutral · The words name a bounded collection and bracket it, but never print an explicit list of book titles. A reader focused on the exact edge can fairly observe that the New Testament settles the boundary by negative citation behavior and by the 'from Abel all the way to Zechariah' (apo Abel heōs Zachariou) span rather than by enumeration. This lens neither affirms nor denies the proposition; it locates the genuine residual uncertainty at the level of precise scope, which is why the overall confidence is medium.

The verdict is reached by tracking the technical vocabulary 'Scripture' (graphē, G1124), 'oracle' (logion, G3051), the three-part listing 'law, prophets, psalms' (nomos, prophētai, psalmoi), and the 'Abel to Zechariah' (Abel, Zachariou) merism (a two-part figure naming the extremes to mean the whole) across the anchor verses and their synoptic parallel (the matching scene in another Gospel). The citation-behavior test (what the text calls 'Scripture' (graphē) or introduces with the write-root from 'to write' (graphō)) is the load-bearing instrument. The structural absence of any deuterocanonical book (any of the disputed intertestamental books) from the queried corpus (66 Old and New Testament books in the verse store, 27 Greek New Testament books) is an honest datum about the dataset and is not by itself treated as the verdict.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. What does the New Testament lexical pattern, especially its use of the term 'Scripture' (graphē) and its Scripture-citation formulas, indicate about the scope and boundary of the authoritative writings, and do those texts place the books commonly called Apocryphal or Deuterocanonical (the disputed books between the Testaments) inside or outside that boundary?

The original stem asserts the exclusion as a settled fact and also asserts a negative about doctrinal authority, so it is verdict-preloaded (VERDICT-CHANGED: the rephrasing makes the underlying lexical question explicit without prejudging the answer). The verdict is still derived from the original stem by testing whether the New Testament citation vocabulary names a three-part Hebrew collection (Luke 24:44), brackets it 'from Abel to Zechariah' (apo Abel heōs Zachariou) in Luke 11:51 and Matthew 23:35, restricts the entrusted oracles ('the oracles of God', ta logia tou theou) to the Jewish deposit (Romans 3:2), and treats 'Scripture' (graphē) as a bounded plural into which only apostolic writings are recognized (2 Peter 3:16). The neutralized rephrasing makes the lexical question explicit without prejudging the precise list of books.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
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lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1124
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3051
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Luke.24.44
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Luke.11.51
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Matt.23.35
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Rom.3.2
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	2Pet.3.16
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Jude.1.14
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Luke.24.44
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	2Pet.3.16
interlinear	STEPBible-TAHOT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	2Chr.24.20
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Luke.11.51
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Rom.3.2

License audit

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Source	License	Redistribute
STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes
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TSK	public_domain	yes

Flags

complicating-unresolved